

4 new Vostros

Dell launches four new Vostro 3000 laptops in India, with Sandy Bridge processors

Honeycomb updates

ASUS and Acer Tablets to get Android 3.1 update in June

Netbook test

as 30percent, which is crucial if you want to increase battery life on the move. Surprisingly, the Champion WBook's screen is possibly the best of the lot. While the top end brightness level may not match those of the Acer Aspire One or the Asus Eee PC 1018P, the WBook's colours are much softer and the display causes least eye strain even after long hours of use.

Netbooks have a size limitation in terms of width, and the keyboard does tend to be smaller as a result, at least when compared to the keyboard on a full-fledged laptop. Immediately noticeable is the lack of a dedicated number pad. Secondly, the space between



Asus Eee PC 1008P Karim Rashid Edition

the keys is reduced. The most popular keyboard style doing rounds is the chiclet-styled one. The Samsung NF210 a well spaced out keyboard, which is the closest you will feel to the keyboard of a full-fledged laptop. The Asus Eee PC netbooks 1008P (Karim Rashid edition), the 1018P and the 1015PW have the most

HOW WE TESTED

To avoid fragmenting the netbooks into unnecessary categories, we have not divided them into any categories. Simply because the price bracket all of these fall in is relatively narrow. Secondly, the basic specifications are very similar across the models we have tested.

Readying the machine

To ensure a level testing platform across all machines, there are certain steps that we followed before the benchmarking began. First, all third party applications and software were uninstalled. The motive behind this is to ensure that no services/tasks are not running in the background and eating up precious system resources. The second reason is that while particular software may be installed in one netbook, it isn't necessary that another netbook may have that on board. Testing without cleaning up the system would have created an uneven platform for comparing. Once the applications have been uninstalled, the registry is cleaned using the CCleaner software. This to ensure any elements/broken entries etc. that an uninstalled app may have left behind is cleaned up.

After this, the power settings were set at a standard level across all machines. Power plan was set to "High Performance", and automatic stand-by and hibernate modes were disabled, and select the battery to shutdown when it drains out. Processor clock speeds were set to 100%.

The hard drive was defragmented as well, to ensure that the files are placed uniformly across the drives, in all netbooks. Disk fragmentation seriously compromises system performance. The virtual memory across netbooks is set to 2048MB, manually.

Battery life is an extremely critical element of the overall performance offered by a netbook. To ensure the most accurate test results, the battery in all netbooks is fully charged (exact 100%, nothing less), before the battery test is started.

Testing the performance

The performance of the netbooks is tested in two separate ways- straightforward benchmarking and real-world tests. For Benchmarking, the PC Mark 2005 is used to derive scores for the CPU, memory and the hard drive. Straightforward scores offered here tend to give an idea of which machine has more raw power. 3D Mark 06 is used in laptops to test the graphics capabilities. Since netbooks do not usually come with powerful graphics solutions, these scores tend to be very low- indicating very basic (too harsh to call it mediocre?) performance.

Once the benchmarks are done with, the real world tests come into play. Build quality and ergonomics are rated here, on a scale of 10. HD video playback, speaker volume and clarity, file transfer between partitions and the wireless connectivity speeds are tested.

comfortable keyboards, with a nice amount of travel and a solid feel. The HP Mini's keyboard however is extremely disappointing. It has a distinctly plastic feel, the key response isn't very consistent and can be extremely noisy if typing fast. Some don't have the chiclet-styled keyboard,

though. Acer Aspire One's Island style keyboard feels extremely comfortable to use, and despite the lack of space between the keys, the fingers don't feel cramped, owing to the really large keys. The Champion WBook has a completely different keyboard style. Neither Chiclet nor Island, this

keyboard is the one we saw on the previous generation of notebooks. The keys are much chunkier, stand at a slightly higher elevation than the Chiclet styled one and offer a lot more travel too. While the key press response is consistent, it takes some time to get used to the extra key travel.



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